A Study of Correlation Between Social Media Gambling Ads and Problem Gambling in Young People

Aidan Mistry (46510)

BAA1010

Doctor Michael Farayola

April 17th, 2026

Main Word Count: 3598

Critical Reflection Word Count: 562

(Excluding Title Page and Appendices)

Executive Summary

This paper addresses the research question: How has the promotion of the expanding online gambling industry contributed to the increase in gambling rates among young people? It argues that promotion has played a significant role in increasing gambling sign-up, intensity, and normalisation among young adults aged 18-25, though the strength of this relationship varies by jurisdiction. The evidence does not suggest that only advertising creates demand. Instead, promotion acts as an accelerator within an environment of increased availability with mobile gambling apps and frictionless digital payments. Across studies, repeated exposure is linked to more favourable attitudes, lower risk perception, higher brand recall, and stronger intentions to bet, particularly online and in sports-related contexts (Bouguettaya et al., 2020; Rossi and Nairn, 2022; Singer et al., 2024; McGrane et al., 2025).

Key mechanisms explain how promotion contributes to increased gambling among young people. Algorithmic and direct marketing increase exposure by targeting users already engaged with sports or related content. Influencer and celebrity endorsements enhance trust and perceived legitimacy. Closely linked is native advertising, which blurs the line between entertainment and promotion, making persuasive content harder to identify. Fourth, the saturation of gambling in sports and digital culture normalises betting as part of everyday leisure. Fifth, official statistics show that young adults remain a key risk group. In Canada, 32% of 18-29-year-olds reported online gambling, with 23.5% experiencing high harm. In Australia, monthly betting among men aged 18-24 rose from 10% in 2015 to 17% in 2022. In Great Britain, while 18-24 year-olds were least likely to gamble overall, those who did engaged in the highest number of activities(Canadian Centre on Substance Use and Addiction, 2025; Australian Institute of Health and Welfare, 2025; Gambling Commission, 2025; Young *et al.*, 2025)

The causal case is strongest where long-term evidence exists. In Spain, marketing expenditure was linked to increases in accounts, deposits, and total betting, with regulation weakening these effects (García-Pérez et al., 2024). In Belgium, recall of gambling promotion during UEFA Euro 2024 was associated with increased betting, mainly through social norms and perceived control (Jacobs et al., 2025). While isolating advertising's independent effect is difficult, the evidence shows that promotion contributes to rising youth gambling rates by increasing exposure, reducing barriers, correlating it with sports and embedding gambling in everyday life.

Introduction

The research question is not whether young adults gamble solely because of exposure to gambling promotion, but whether the promotion of the rapidly expanding digital gambling industry has contributed to increased gambling rates among young people. Framed this way, evidence suggests that it has. Promotion operates within a wider commercial environment that includes 24/7 online access, mobile apps, push notifications, influencer marketing, sports sponsorship, and data-driven retention strategies. (Thomas *et al.*, 2023) Recent academic papers increasingly treat gambling as a public health issue. Caused by not only individual choice but also by the strategies of the commercial gambling sector (Singer et al., 2024).

This paper utilises third-party evidence, including peer-reviewed articles, official statistics, and regulatory documents, with a focus on individuals aged 18-25. A key methodological issue is that much of the strongest exposure literature focuses on under-18s due to regulatory concerns. However, this evidence remains important, as the influence of advertisement does not disappear at age 18 and may become more significant once individuals can legally access markets. Official sources in Canada and Ireland identify young adults as a particularly vulnerable group in the current environment. (Young *et al.*, 2025; Canadian Centre on Substance Use and Addiction, 2024; Moodie *et al.*, 2024)

Recent policy developments reinforce this perspective. In Ontario, restrictions on athlete and influencer-led gambling advertising were introduced due to youth susceptibility, effective February 2024. In Ireland, the Gambling Regulation Act 2024 introduces advertising limits, including a watershed and restrictions on social media targeting. At the EU level, the Digital Services Act restricts profiling-based advertising to minors and increases transparency requirements. These measures indicate that regulators increasingly view targeting, platform design, and digital persuasion as key drivers of harm. (Alcohol and Gaming Commission of Ontario, 2023)

This paper argues that promotion contributes to increased gambling among young adults through cumulative effects. It normalises gambling, reduces the gap between watching sports and betting, and attracts users with personalised marketing. Even where overall youth participation does not rise consistently, young adults remain more engaged in higher-risk forms and more exposed to harm. (Young et al., 2025)

Evidence-Based Findings

Recent literature spans many countries and topics, so a map outlining the design, area and main findings of the various sources helps create a layout to easily view some of the main points taken from the literature.

Study	Design and sample	Jurisdiction	Main finding for this question
Rossi and Nairn (2022)	Review of social media gambling advertising research	Mainly UK/Australia	Social media gambling ads are high-volume, youth-facing, and especially concerning as paid ads target specific audiences while organic content spreads through peer networks.
Singer et al. (2024)	Systematic review of 12 peer-reviewed studies from 2021 onward	Cross-jurisdictional	Social media advertising intensity and complexity are increasing; the line between advertising and neutral content is blurring; vulnerable groups are at particular risk.
Pitt et al. (2024)	Qualitative focus groups with 64 young people aged 12 - 17	Australia	Celebrities and influencers increase attention, trust, legitimacy, and social acceptance while lowering perceived risk.
Moodie et al. (2024)	One-to-one interviews with 16 young adults aged 18 -34, split by risk profile	Ireland	Participants reported high exposure, frequent inducements, and stated that promotions could prompt larger or more frequent gambling than intended.
Noble et al. (2022)	Survey analysis of the 2017 ASSAD school survey	Australia	Online gambling ad exposure was significantly associated with gambling in the last month and with at-risk/problem gambling.
Di Censo et al. (2024)	Youth-focused problem gambling study	UK/Australia-relevant youth context	Sports betting advertising may predict problem gambling scores even after accounting for non-marketing variables.
García-Pérez et al. (2024)	Longitudinal SARIMA analysis of 2013-2023 administrative data	Spain	Advertising, promotions, and sponsorship significantly increased new accounts, active accounts, deposits, and total money bet.

Jacobs et al. (2025)	Cross-sectional survey of 1,611 adults who watched EURO 2024	Belgium	Better recall of gambling communication was associated with a higher likelihood of betting, mainly through perceived descriptive norms.

Algorithmic Exposure

The evidence for algorithmic targeting remains speculative, as social media targeting ad systems are proprietary. However, existing research points in a clear direction. Rossi and Nairn (2022) distinguish between paid social media advertising, where companies pay social media companies for precise targeted placement, and organic promotion that spreads through shares and followers. They argue that paid ads can target “specific young people,” with users engaged in sports or gambling-related content likely to be “bombarded” with repeated ads. Singer et al. (2024) reach a similar conclusion, highlighting the use of native ads from influencers and the increasing use of non-explicit advertisements.

Behavioural evidence is strongest in direct marketing studies. Syvertsen et al. (2020) interviewed individuals with current or lifetime gambling disorders and found that gambling companies used tailored offers such as free credits, bonuses, and reactivation incentives. Participants believed promotions adapted to their activity and described them as predatory and urge-triggering. While not limited to young adults, these participants show how personalised marketing operates once users enter the system. (Syvertsen *et al.*, 2020) Moodie et al. (2024) provide evidence from Ireland among 18-34 year-olds, where participants reported familiarity with sign-up offers, free bets, and loyalty schemes, with some stating these promotions led them to bet or deposit more than intended.

Regulatory responses suggest policymakers increasingly view these practices as structural risks. Ireland’s Gambling Regulation Act 2024 restricts social media advertising to users who follow operators and requires consent-based marketing. At the EU level, the Digital Services Act prohibits profiling-based advertising to minors and mandates transparency in these systems. These measures reflect a growing recognition that algorithmic targeting is central to modern gambling promotion. However, there is still limited evidence distinguishing whether 18-25-year-olds are targeted compared to older groups. (Law Reform Commission of Ireland, 2024; Singer, Wöhr and Otterbach, 2024)

Influencer and Celebrity Marketing

Social media influencers are an increasing source of gambling promotion. In focus groups with 64 adolescents, Pitt et al. (2024) found that celebrities and influencers were seen as attention-grabbing and familiar, indicating that the focus group participants

recognised them as gambling promoters. However, the influencers also increased participants' trust and social acceptance while lowering perceived risk. This perception shifts gambling from a risky activity to a socially endorsed practice. (Pitt *et al.*, 2024) This helps explain why influencer gambling promotion remains effective even when users understand its risks.

This pattern is reflected in official data. The UK Gambling Commission's 2025 survey found that among the 16% of young respondents who followed gambling-related content, 31% reported exposure to influencer-led promotion. In Ireland, research from Maynooth University and Ulster University shows that traditional advertising now plays a smaller role, with companies relying more on social media content and partnerships with influencers and sports figures to engage younger audiences. (Gambling Commission, 2025a)

Regulatory responses highlight the perceived risk of this approach. In Ontario, the Alcohol and Gaming Commission restricted the use of athletes and celebrities likely to appeal to minors, with updated standards implemented in February 2024. Social media influencers were explicitly included in these restrictions. Although framed around minors, these measures are relevant to 18-25-year-olds, as the same celebrity influence continues into early adulthood. (Alcohol and Gaming Commission of Ontario, 2023)

Native Advertising and Content Marketing

A key shift in gambling promotion is the move from overt advertising to native, brand-inflected content that is harder to recognise as advertising. Rossi and Nairn's research is central here. Their 2024 study found that gambling content on X was significantly more appealing to children and young adults aged 18-24 than to older groups. Their 2025 recognizability study showed that 40-50% of gambling adverts were content marketing, with children and young adults demonstrating significantly lower recognition rates, often close to chance level. (Rossi and Nairn, 2024a)

Singer et al. (2024) frame this as a broader structural issue: as social media marketing intensifies, the boundary between advertising and neutral content becomes increasingly blurred. This shift changes the cognitive task for users. Traditional advertising asks whether the viewer wants to engage; content marketing first requires users to recognise that persuasion is occurring. For young adults embedded in sports and creator-driven media environments, this distinction is critical. (Rossi and Nairn, 2024b)

Official evidence reinforces this point. The UK Gambling Commission (2025) found that young people in Britain encountered gambling branding embedded in social media, sports apps, and events, often "slipping under the radar." Examples included gambling logos in press conferences and odds displayed within score apps. The Irish "Code Red" research

reaches a similar conclusion, identifying social media and video highlights as key channels for repeated exposure. Native promotion is therefore influential not only because it persuades, but because it becomes constant, embedded within the background of sport, reinforcing an association between sports and gambling. (Gambling Commission, 2025b)

Cultural Normalisation

Normalisation links exposure to behaviour by making gambling appear common and socially acceptable (Jacobs *et al.*, 2025). Nyemcsok et al. (2024) found that Australian young people viewed gambling as a routine part of everyday life and increasingly normal in sport. Earlier UK research by Djohari et al. (2019) similarly found strong brand recall in sport settings, with most respondents viewing betting as a normal part of sport. In Canada, the Canadian Centre on Substance Use and Addiction warns that repeated pairing of sport and betting in advertising reinforces this perception and embeds gambling within sports fandom.

Irish evidence highlights how normalisation operates through language and perception. In the “Code Red” study, young participants described gambling sponsorship in sport as a “natural” relationship, reflecting how promotion reframes gambling as culturally embedded rather than commercial. Once this shift occurs, age restrictions become less effective, as normalisation precedes legal participation. ESRI (2024) supports this, suggesting that for younger groups, external influences such as marketing and accessibility may now outweigh parental influence in shaping gambling risk. (Kerr, Kitchin and O’Brennan, 2024)

Jacobs et al. (2025) add an additional dimension. In their study of EURO 2024 viewers, recall of gambling promotion increased betting likelihood, primarily through perceived social norms and secondarily through the illusion of control. Promotion, therefore, both created a perceived control and likely contributed to the viewer's decision to gamble.

Growth in Gambling Behaviour Using Official Statistics

Official statistics don’t show a single consistent pattern across jurisdictions, but the various patterns identified indicate that young adults are highly exposed to online betting-focused ads. (Kerr, Kitchin and O’Brennan, 2024) The clearest growth trend appears in Australia. The Australian Institute of Health and Welfare reports that betting is most common in men aged 18-34, with the proportion of men aged 18-24 who bet monthly rising from 10% in 2015 to 17% in 2022. Betting among men overall increased from 5.6% to 9.3%, alongside growth in high-risk gambling from 1.1% in 2018 to 1.8% in 2022. The AIHW links these increases to greater accessibility and promotion through apps and social media. (Australian Institute of Health and Welfare, 2023)

In Canada, the Canadian Centre on Substance Use and Addiction connected post-2021 policy changes with expanded opportunities for online gambling and increased advertising across multiple platforms. A 2025 report found that 32% of 18-29-year-olds engaged in online gambling, with 23.5% of those users reporting high levels of harm. Young adults were also more likely to gamble online than participate in alternative gambling sources such as the lottery, with online activity linked to higher risk indicators. While advertising is not isolated as the sole cause, these findings support the argument that promotion and accessibility have expanded together, disproportionately affecting young adults. (Canadian Centre on Substance Use and Addiction, 2024)

In Great Britain, the pattern is more complex. The 2024 Gambling Survey shows that 18-24-year-olds were the least likely group to gamble in the past four weeks at 36%, down slightly from 2023. However, they recorded the highest average number of gambling activities at 3.3. This suggests that while overall participation may be lower, engagement among those who do gamble is broader. Among under-18s, 69% reported exposure to gambling advertising in 2024, with around one in six following gambling-related content online, particularly on TikTok and YouTube. These data highlight the pre-18 promotional environment shaping future consumers. (Gambling Commission, 2024a)

Ireland's data is limited but points in the same direction. ESRI (2026) estimates that 1 in 30 adults experience problem gambling, while its 2024 research shows that early exposure significantly increases later risk. Public health reports also note frequent, often unavoidable exposure to gambling marketing among young adults, particularly through television and social media. (Ceallaigh *et al.*, 2023)

Discussion

Together, this evidence presents strong correlations and provides a foundation to answer the paper's research question. The promotion of online gambling contributes to increased gambling among young people by lowering psychological and practical barriers between interest and action. Gambling marketing does more than display the product; it creates emotional cues and prompts for immediate engagement. (Bouguettaya *et al.*, 2020) This can be done explicitly with ads through influencer endorsement or social media content. But alternatively can be done subtly, for example, in apps that display sports scores, also showing betting lines and odds. The cumulative effect is an environment where gambling is detached from feelings of risk and is easy to act upon. (Pitt *et al.*, 2024; Gambling Commission, 2025b)

This aligns with broader research. Bouguettaya et al. (2020) identify associations between advertising exposure and gambling attitudes and behaviour. McGrane et al. (2025)

find that sports-related gambling advertising is linked to increased gambling behaviour across multiple media formats. Singer et al. (2024) highlight the increasing complexity of social media targeting algorithms, while Thomas et al. (2023) argue that gambling promotion should be treated as a public health threat rather than a narrow advertisement concern. (Bouguettaya *et al.*, 2020)

Three key mechanisms explain these effects: exposure intensity, normalisation, and inducements. Repeated exposure increases familiarity with gambling platforms. Normalisation shifts perceptions of legitimacy and social acceptance using celebrities and integration with sporting events. Inducements convert interest into action, such as a user signing up because of a bonus. This is reflected in longitudinal evidence. In Spain, increased spending on advertising, bonuses, and sponsorship was associated with rises in online gambling activity, including new accounts and total bets. In Belgium, exposure during EURO 2024 was linked to betting through perceived norms and the illusion of control. While not definitive, these findings move past simple similarity-based evidence. (García-Pérez, Krotter and Aonso-Diego, 2024)

However, the evidence requires interpretation. Much of the literature is cross-sectional, self-reported, and concentrated in specific regions. Many exposure studies focus on adolescents rather than 18-25-year-olds, despite their importance to active policy. Official statistics are also difficult to compare across jurisdictions, making it easier to identify mechanisms than to produce a single global trend. (Australian Institute of Health and Welfare, 2023)

Promotion is also closely linked with availability. (Young *et al.*, 2024) Canada's post-2021 law change allowed for more freedoms in gambling services and the advertising of them, reducing separation. Rather than weakening the argument, this suggests that promotion and availability reinforce each other. Advertising is more effective when access is immediate, and availability becomes more impactful when gambling is normalised and encouraged through advertising (Canadian Centre on Substance Use and Addiction, 2024). Overall, the evidence supports the conclusion that promotion plays a meaningful role in increasing youth gambling within a broader system of digital accessibility and cultural normalisation.

Contribution & Implications

The main contribution of this paper is conceptual as well as evidential. It shows that promotion contributes to increased gambling rates among young adults through a sequence of linked mechanisms: targeted exposure, unnoticed persuasion, cultural normalisation through sport and creators, and triggers into betting behaviour. This behavioural path is

observed in multiple studies, which all focused on different steps of the process. Gambling ads seek to trigger this sequence in order to procure new customers. This refines existing literature by demonstrating the process by which advertisements acquire new customers in a social media market. (Rossi and Nairn, 2022)

The policy implications follow directly from that account. First, regulation should move beyond conventional ad bans toward system-level controls on profiling, recommender-driven amplification, affiliate and influencer promotion, and retention marketing. The Irish framework is notable because it combines watershed restrictions with targeting limits and consent requirements. The Ontario reforms are notable because they address athlete and influencer branding rather than only explicit “children’s appeals.” The EU’s profiling restrictions for minors and Britain’s tighter direct-marketing opt-in rules also point in this direction. Second, warning messages should be designed independently of industry, because Irish young adults in qualitative work were openly sceptical of small, vague, operator-controlled “responsible gambling” messages. (Law Reform Commission of Ireland, 2024)

There are also practical implications for universities, sports bodies, and digital platforms. Universities serving 18-25-year-olds should not assume that gambling is a marginal student issue; Irish university research found a concerning level of problematic gambling in a 397-student sample, especially among those using mobile gambling apps and online accounts. Sports organisations should recognise that the commercial symbiosis between betting and fandom is itself part of the harm pathway. Platforms cannot plausibly treat gambling as just another ad category if their recommendation and creator systems repeatedly surface gambling-adjacent content to younger users. (Murphy, Murphy and Roberts, 2024)

Limitations & Future Research

A major limitation of the present evidence base is the absence of age-specific official time series across jurisdictions. Some official sources report overall adult participation, others report online-only behaviour, others highlight harm rather than prevalence, and many do not view the age bracket of 18-25, newer adults who may be more impressionable, separately from adjacent groups such as 18-29 or 18-34. This makes comparison between different countries imperfect. In addition, many young-adult studies remain cross-sectional and self-reported, while the majority of detailed exposure studies often centre on minors rather than emerging adults (Gambling Commission, 2024a). Additionally, when attempting to initially start the research process, the paper was intended to utilise primary data collected via an administered questionnaire. However, the initial questionnaire was a trial run with a small group, and the results did not produce anything actionable. The group the

questionnaire was tested with responded to most questions with "unsure.” However, through secondary research, it is easy to identify why, as many of the dangers of social media gambling promotion are in its subtlety, and users would not have answers for specific questions. This reinforces the main point of what to prioritise in future research as outlined below.

Future research should be centred around longitudinal designs. Four directions can be utilised to improve data: first, platform-level audits of gambling advertising, influencer promotion, and recommended content, in order to set a baseline for different social media sites. Second, behavioural data can test whether viewing inducements predicts deposits or bet frequency. Similar to the first point, this can be established with a baseline. Third, evaluations performed before and after regulatory changes such as Ireland’s 2024 Act or Ontario’s 2024 influencer restrictions. Finally, a better 18-25 sampling range beyond male sports fans, including women, non-students, and minority communities. ESRI’s Irish review has already highlighted the need for behavioural audits of marketing techniques and experiments on the effects of different forms of marketing in Ireland. Effectively, an ideal study would be one that is longitudinal, focused on a diverse group aged 18-25, this correlated with Singer et al. (2024), who call for longitudinal and machine-learning-supported research to track dynamic social media strategies. (Ceallaigh *et al.*, 2023)

Critical Reflection

When I became aware of Business Project, I was still in my third year, and the students in the year above me were explaining how your thesis could be on essentially anything as long as it had a business tie-in. So I began brainstorming and identified a topic and potential research question for when I took the class the following year. However, when the class began, we had to place our topic under three specific categories, so I had to pivot my idea to fall under one of the three categories. This pivot proved difficult at first, as it made me less motivated in my topic and meant that many of the plans I had for my original project were no longer applicable, and I found my research skills to be lacking. I previously identified issues with critical reading, searching and digesting academic articles. While my initial topic was a field in which I was knowledgeable and I felt more confident in being able to find sources when I knew what I was searching for, starting fresh posed a challenge. While I had a slow start, I improved these skills and digested articles and papers in a more effective manner than before.

If I had to do something differently, I would start my literature search process earlier. After my literature review, I identified better articles; if I had found them when I did my literature review, I could have had a more consistent process towards this research paper.

The multiple changes in articles and subthemes sometimes left my work process disorganised and harder to complete. Additionally, I set myself back by entering the class with expectations that were not met. Given that I was expecting to have a higher degree of freedom and do a topic I was immensely passionate about, the forced switch decresed by enthusiasm and caused me to delay the start of projects in place of other classes. Eventually, I improved and devoted more time to the project. In future projects of this size, I intend to approach with no expectations. I feel that being able to work through the lack of motivation will also serve me well in a professional setting where the project or work may not always be as fulfilling or enjoyable as you would like it to be, but ultimately must still get done.

I feel that this course has contributed to my personal development in terms of being able to focus on a project over a longer period of time. I often like to do projects in the span of a few days, but for my thesis, given the year-long structure, I was able to work more slowly and gradually. I found it helpful to avoid major time constraints, take my time and be able to come back and revisit the project with a fresh perspective. Professionally, I feel that a project of this size and length is similar to what I will eventually be encountering in the workplace. While maybe not an exact equal, sustained effort on a singular project is an important skill set that employers value, and one I feel this project has helped me learn. While the direct things done in this course may not always apply to a professional, I think adjacent skills will be beneficial to me as I take the next step in my career.

Appendix A

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APPENDIX B

Generative AI Declaration Statement

Declaration Statement

Please tick the appropriate box relating to your use of Gen AI tools for the module Business Strategy (BAA1019)

A. ☐ I did not use any Gen AI tools (including for editing and proofreading) in the completion of this assignment

B.☑ I did use Gen AI tools in the completion of this assignment

Signature: Aidan Mistry

Date: April 17th, 2026

Appendix C

Reporting of Gen AI Tool Use in Assignments

Tools: ChatGPT, used between 25/02/2026 - 17/04/2026	Tools: ChatGPT, used between 25/02/2026 - 17/04/2026	Tools: ChatGPT, used between 25/02/2026 - 17/04/2026
Outputs: ChatGPT was used in searching for sources.	Outputs: I used ChatGPT to assist in paper brainstorming and planning	Outputs: As I reached the maximum word count, ChatGPT was utilised to identify points that were repeated excessively in my writings
Prompts: Identify academic papers relating to my research question "..."	Prompts: Relating to Native ads, what are the major benefits and drawbacks to consumers	Prompts: Read this paper and identify themes or points that are stated too many times, as well as any overly long wordy sentences
Critical Reflection: For this assignment, I utilised generative AI to assist in applications of my existing knowledge. Utilised primarily as a resource for research and structuring, at no point did AI write anything directly for this paper. I viewed my usage as bouncing ideas off someone knowledgeable on the topic, using outputs to steer myself in the correct direction.		